

ries, something that is rare amongst distros that embrace the Kiss principle.

Commercial Linux Distros often have the disadvantage of competing with distros that rebuild the same code and distribute the operating system for free. CentOS is an example of this phenomenon, which is a slight variation of the Red Hat Enterprise Linux. However, the popularity of Red Hat is still far greater because of the support Red Hat offers, tearing down the myth that open source software is not commercially viable. CentOS releases tend to follow close on the heels of a new Red Hat release, and is meant for enterprise computation. The distro is rpm-based and uses yum to resolve dependencies and handle packages.

Debian is a large, comprehensive distro, driven by a dedicated community of volunteer developers. One of the biggest success stories of Linux, a large number of distros are derived from Debian. Packages are handled in the .deb format, and the default dependency resolver is apt-get. There have been ports of Debian to different kernels as well, including BSD and GNU. Debian is usually used with the Gnome Desktop Environment, which is common to many of the distros derived from Debian. Debian has regular releases, with one of the largest software repositories.

Fedora 10 has been released recently, and is one of the most common distros for servers. Fedora has a large repository, uses rpm packages and yum to resolve dependencies. Fedora is the distro of choice for the creator of Linux, Trovalds himself. Fedora comes with a choice of KDE and Gnome desktop environment. Fedora is a mature and robust distribution to try out.

Gentoo has a novel approach amongst distros, where every software, and the operating system itself is compiled and optimised for the hardware on which it is running. This is achieved by an engine called catalyst. This means that Gentoo is the distro for power users who want to get the most out of their operating system. Although packages take a lot longer to install on Gentoo because of the added compilation time, the very latest builds of software are supported by this distro because of the way it is built. For example, although OpenOffice.org 3.0 was available by the time Ubuntu 8.10 was out, Ubuntu 8.10 was not able to include the latest version of OpenOffice.org along with the distro. Linux Mint 6, which is based on Ubuntu 8.10, also could not offer the latest version of OpenOffice.org. Such restrictions are absurd for Gentoo, and the latest releases of all software can always be compiled on this distro.